Ka Chu. In many ways, this is the book he always wanted to write, and I was grateful for the few extra weeks he got in his sickbed that allowed him to read through the manuscript. My big regret is that I could not publish and release the book before he passed away in March 2015.

I owe a debt of gratitude to dozens of young officers and men who acted as my liaison officers and support units as we trudged across Arunachal from one location to the other where the men had stood and died. Lieutenant Colonels I. P. Singh from 5 Rajput, Vinod Chengappa from 19 Mahar and Amit Sharma from the EME are but a few from a list of many. It was a poignant moment when, sitting on top of a bunker looking towards Tawang from Nuranang, I realized that my liaison officer had tears rolling down his cheek. 'Our generals failed us here,' he said, his voice steady despite the obvious emotion, 'they abandoned these defences. If only we had been allowed to fight, we would have avenged 7 Infantry Brigade here itself.'

The writing of the book spanned many months and I must thank Aienla Ozukum for firmly keeping me on track. Pujitha Krishnan edited the book and I'm grateful to her for her insightful inputs. My thanks to Bena Sareen for designing the cover.

Finally, my grateful thanks to my family—my mother Usha who, as my father loved to say, followed the drum through thick and thin. When 2 Rajput was deployed in Walong, my mother made the epic journey from Ujjain, where my grandfather was posted, all the way to Tezu with me as a three-month-old baby. The last leg of the journey was across the Digaru River on an elephant that belonged to 2 Assam Rifles. While my father was holding me in his lap, sitting comfortably in front, my mother was 'trailing behind, half drowning, desperately holding the tail of the elephant'. Chakoman Gohain, the Tai Khampti raja, had built a bamboo hut for us to live in. I would spend some delightful evenings with him years later while filming the Namdapha Tiger Reserve as a part of the Project Tiger series, listening to his version of the Battle of Walong.

I must thank my wife Dipti, who as usual was a constant sounding board, helped with not just the research and the structure of the narration, but in so many little ways that I happily take for granted. Both my daughters, Vallika and Veeha, worked tirelessly and painstakingly on the dozen maps that appear in the book, going over various references in minute detail, while constantly helping out with various suggestions. And